

# **The Celebration of Cultural Cannibalism in the Opening Ceremony of the 2016**

## **Rio Olympics**

The opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics was a major cultural event that celebrated Brazilian culture and identity. Because of its unprecedented outreach to the international community, it was an opportunity for Brazil to display its complexity and its uniqueness in a heavily mediatized event. The ceremony was specifically designed to showcase the diversity of Brazil's history and culture, including its Indigenous heritage, African roots, and European influences. One of the key themes of the ceremony was cannibalism, or antropofagia, which was used as a metaphor for Brazil's cultural identity. The concept of cannibalism was derived from the Cannibalist Manifesto of Oswald de Andrade, a Brazilian writer that decided to embrace Brazil's cultural heritage in new ways and played a big role in the Semana de Artes Moderna of 1921.

The main objective of this paper is to analyze how the opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics celebrated cannibalism, as defined in Oswald de Andrade's manifesto. This will involve a close analysis of the key elements of the ceremony, including the use of local and international references, the incorporation of indigenous mythologies, the fast rhythm with a succession of claims without unity and a common measure, the abrupt and constant change of topic, and the vision of the movement as a continuity of foreign culture. As a focus point

throughout the essay, we will ask ourselves: how did the opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics celebrate cannibalism of European culture as per Oswald de Andrade's Manifesto?

The paper will begin with an overview of Oswald de Andrade's Cannibalist Manifesto and its significance for Brazilian culture. It will also analyze the manifesto's themes and arguments and examine its impact on Brazilian literature and art.

The analysis of the key segments of the opening ceremony will be presented in the second section of the paper. This part will focus on the performance, the history of Brazil, the building of contemporary Brazil, the passing of the Olympic torch, and the speeches delivered during the ceremony.

Thirdly, the paper will provide a detailed analysis of the cannibalistic theme in the opening ceremony. It will explain how the theme was celebrated and examine the use of the cannibalistic theme in the ceremony. The section will also discuss the relationship between the theme and Oswald de Andrade's Manifesto and its significance for Brazilian culture.

Oswald de Andrade's Cannibalist Manifesto is a seminal text in Brazilian cultural history. It proposed the concept of cultural cannibalism, advocating that Brazil should "devour" foreign culture and transform it into something uniquely Brazilian. This manifesto was a reaction to European cultural dominance in Brazil and a call to embrace Brazil's own cultural heritage, particularly that of its indigenous peoples. The manifesto reflects Andrade's deep engagement

with cultural and social issues and his rejection of the notion that Brazil should continue to imitate European culture. Instead, he argued that Brazil should draw upon its own cultural roots to create a unique and distinct cultural identity.

Written in 1928, Oswald de Andrade's Cannibalist Manifesto was a prominent figure in the Brazilian avant-garde movement of modernism, reflecting his deep engagement with cultural and social issues, following the Semana de Arte Moderna. Andrade's manifesto was a reaction to European cultural dominance in Brazil and a call to embrace Brazil's own cultural heritage, particularly that of its indigenous peoples. The Cannibalist Manifesto emerged in the context of Brazilian cultural history during the early 20th century. The Semana de Arte Moderna, which occurred in 1922, marked a significant turning point in Brazilian cultural history and showcased a range of artistic and literary works, marking the beginning of Brazilian modernism and reflecting a growing interest in developing a unique Brazilian cultural identity through the importance of cultural diversity and the rejection of cultural imperialism.

The manifesto has had a significant impact on Brazilian literature and art, influencing later artistic and literary movements. It is widely regarded as a seminal work in Brazilian modernism, inspiring generations of Brazilian artists and writers to embrace their own cultural heritage and to create art that reflects the unique characteristics of Brazil's cultural identity. The use of the cannibalistic theme in the opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics is a significant example of how the concept of cultural cannibalism has been embraced and celebrated in Brazil. The event provided a visually stunning and culturally significant representation of Brazil, emphasizing its traditions and modernity, while also conveying important social and environmental messages. In addition to the use of the cannibalistic theme in the opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics,

the concept of cultural cannibalism has also been embraced in other areas of Brazilian art and culture. For example, the recent exhibition "Contra Memoria" explores the theme of cultural cannibalism, with various art pieces revisiting past themes and cultural objects to give them a new sense of self.

Furthermore, Andrade's Cannibalist Manifesto has had a significant impact on Brazilian politics and social movements. Jung's article on the 2014 World Cup and 2016 Olympics argues that a new form of civic nationalism emerged in Brazil during these events, with an emphasis on inclusion and diversity (Jung, 2022). This new idea of the cultural resonance that Brazil should export drew heavily on the ideas of cultural cannibalism, with a focus on embracing Brazil's diverse cultural heritage as a means of promoting national unity and pride.

The opening ceremony of the Olympic Games took place in Maracana in Rio, marking the first Olympic Games in South America. Despite concerns about Rio's ability to host the Olympics and the World Cup only two years apart, the commentator stated that "every game has the power to inspire" just before the ceremony began. The opening clip showcased Rio's sports, including beaches, urban areas, and forests, with aerial cameras filming traditional sports like golf, horseback riding, and rowing, as well as newer ones like skateboarding, parkour, and capoeira. The performance redefined space as characters moved freely in their surroundings, proving that Rio is a city with sports at its heart.

On stage, there was a contemporary dance/visual art performance using aluminium sheets to create waves, representing the idea of making something out of almost nothing. The

Brazilian anthem was played, and the flag was raised in the middle by the environment police of Rio, with Paulinho da Viola, a Brazilian composer, on the guitar and singing, backed by several classic musicians with violins and chords. Here, a clear contrast can be seen between symbols traditionally considered to be majestic (namely the classical orchestra and the concept of an anthem) and Brazil's capacity to alter them by incorporating its elements in a show that resonates with local fashions, here symbolized by Paulinho da Viola having a central role in this part of the ceremony.

The history of Brazil was also represented, with a projection of the sea, waves, and thunderstorms, followed by the beginning of life, represented by mechanical giant crabs and other insect-like creatures to symbolize wilderness and the omnipresence of the color green. A big wall made of long strips of fabric was erected in the middle of the stage to represent the forest's ecosystem. The indigenous tribes then arrived, dressed only in the traditional red fabric easily recognizable by foreign audiences. They stretched out a strip of the big fabric wall, making a shape that resembled traditional European looms before uniting them into three big tree shapes, symbolizing the Amazonian rainforest and the celebration of the indigenous community.

The arrival of the Europeans, who left a mark both on the stage and in Brazil's history, was then represented, followed by the enslaved Africans, whose culture developed at the intersection of Brazil and Africa. The Arabs from the Orient arrived shortly after, which gave us only a few seconds on the historical issue of slavery, which seems a little too optimistic considering its impact on Brazil. The Japanese arrived with big red flags in the shape of their traditional ships, highlighting their long-standing presence as the biggest foreign diaspora of Japan.

The building of contemporary Brazil was showcased through modern style buildings emerging from the stage, with performers going from roof to roof acrobatically. A whole area of the stage was revealed with more vertical buildings, with performers going freely from one building to another, making up for the intentional lack of personality. The acrobats passed around big white boxes while an instrumental version of the song "Construcao" by Chico Buarque played. This choice of theme is interesting as the lyrics of that song poetically describe the deaths of construction workers and the harsh conditions they live under. A replica of the 14 bis, the first plane flown by the inventor Santos-Dumont, was then paraded around the stadium, showcasing Brazil's capacity for innovation and the clip of its flight through the monuments of Rio de Janeiro not only cover the architectural beauty of the sceneries but also questions the European centrality it took during the industrial revolutions.

The performance also highlighted Brazil's popular culture, including the iconic "Girl from Ipanema" song, followed shortly after by a faster rhythm and synthesized, hip hop, and techno sonorities as well as street dance performers. 86-year-old Elza Soares reconciled the two previous songs, keeping the new sounds of the younger generation but incorporating them with her singing to create timeless music. Later, a solo capoeira performance was backed up by 12-year-old rapper MC Sophia, who touched upon the importance of fighting against intolerance and differences. Finally, there was a samba performance by several samba schools, notably Portela, not necessarily the most famous one, but a consistent organization with unique costume designs due to its limited resources. This segment of performances is overall a showcase of Brazil's diversity of culture and influences.

The use of the cannibalistic theme in the 2016 Rio Olympics opening ceremony was a controversial and provocative artistic choice. Mary O'Neil's analysis of the event in her article for The Guardian points out that the theme generated mixed reactions, and some saw it as being potentially offensive. However, the ceremony aimed to showcase Brazilian culture's diversity and history, incorporating references to the country's indigenous peoples, African slaves, and immigrants who have contributed to its identity. This section will provide a detailed analysis of the cannibalistic theme in the opening ceremony, exploring how the theme was celebrated and examining its use in the event.

Comparatively to the length of the ceremony (4 hours), very few words are spoken, and most of the communication is done either visually with installations and colors, musically with a large and omnipresent variety of songs, or through dance and body expression. This contrasts with the idea that an opening ceremony must be formal, celebrate the competition and its athletes, and welcome everyone. Nevertheless, the audience here is immediately immersed in the show as if it is being devoured. Nevertheless, two speeches have been included at the end of the ceremony; the first one being carried out by the president of the organizing committee, Carlos Arthur Nuzman. But here, once again, a prowess never seen before is played out: done in three languages at once, the speech is complex and precise as there is a continuity in the ideas and a flow that is not stopped by the constant change of languages. Nuzman is able to keep the attention of a stadium of sixty thousand supporters by combining the poetic aspect of French (the official language of the Olympic Games), the outreach of English, and the intensity of emotions of Portuguese. "Hoje, o mundo é carioca" (3:19:00), he claims while the world watches him incorporate all the nations under his. The freedom to tell this to a large audience and the

power he gets from doing so is comparable to that of the manifesto antropofago: both are controversial statements that change the dynamic of the importation of foreign culture in Brazil, leaving the passive consumerism to enter an active will of incorporation.

The passing of the Olympic torch is another key element of the ceremony, and in a similar fashion to previous events, the torch holder ran all the way from outside the stadium until it reached the central stage and passed it on. What Brazil stood out for here is the position the Olympic flame took in the ceremony. Indeed, once lit up, the Olympic flame of the Maracana was lifted and placed at the center of a gigantic installation reflecting the light of the flame through rotating mirrors that multiplied the brightness and sensationalism of the symbol. A direct link to Antropofagia can be made here: taking a timeless symbol of a millennial tradition of sports and ingesting, transforming, then sharing the new identity it took, in this case with the sculpture that as an ornament defying its possessor but also demonstrating the improvements Brazil can bring to the table despite being a relatively new country.

Paulinho da Viola's intervention mentioned earlier also acts as a symbol of dominance that Brazilian culture displays over the world in the ceremony. Alongside the replica of the 14 bis plane, it partially explains why O'Neil saw the provocations as potential weakness of the event. Nonetheless, if the ceremony could have been received as controversial by the international community, as no further position was taken by Brazil afterwards, the consequences did not enter the political sphere and were therefore less impactful. This however is also one of the limits of the ceremony: if Bary in 1991 puts forward the influence that Oswald de Andrade's "Cannibalist Manifesto" had on the Brazilian cultural and political context of the 1920's and 30's, the heritage and legacy aspects of the opening ceremony have yet to emerge. Rather, the

Olympic Games of Rio act as an homage and testifying of the everlasting impact that Andrade's ideas still have on Brazilian culture.

In conclusion, the opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics was a major cultural event that celebrated Brazil's cultural identity and diversity. The concept of cannibalism, derived from Oswald de Andrade's Cannibalist Manifesto, played a significant role in the ceremony, as it served as a metaphor for Brazil's cultural identity. The ceremony showcased Brazil's rich history and culture, including its indigenous heritage, African roots, and European influences, in a heavily mediatized event that reached a global audience.

The paper analyzed how the opening ceremony celebrated cannibalism, as defined in Oswald de Andrade's manifesto, by examining the key elements of the ceremony, including the use of local and international references, the incorporation of indigenous mythologies, and the vision of the movement as a continuity of foreign culture. The analysis showed that the ceremony celebrated cannibalism in a way that reflected Andrade's call to embrace Brazil's own cultural heritage and to create a unique and distinct cultural identity.

The paper also provided an overview of Oswald de Andrade's Cannibalist Manifesto, its significance for Brazilian culture, and its impact on Brazilian literature and art. The manifesto proposed the concept of cultural cannibalism as a means of asserting Brazil's cultural independence and resisting European cultural domination. It emphasized the importance of

cultural diversity and the rejection of cultural imperialism, playing an important role in shaping Brazilian cultural identity.

The opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics provided a stunning representation of Brazil's rich cultural identity and diversity. By embracing the concept of cannibalism, as defined in Oswald de Andrade's manifesto, the ceremony celebrated Brazil's unique cultural heritage and identity, while also conveying important social and environmental messages. The ceremony showcased Brazil's ability to be both traditional and modern, and its commitment to promoting cultural diversity and sustainability. Overall, the opening ceremony of the 2016 Rio Olympics was a remarkable celebration of Brazil's rich cultural identity and its place in the global community.

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